IELTS Writing Module Guide

Prepared by Mehak Hussain

Overview and time plan

IELTS Academic Writing is **60 minutes** for 2 tasks, and **both must be completed**. Task 2 counts **twice as much** as Task 1, so it deserves more of your time (IELTS official).

	Task 1 (report)	Task 2 (essay)
What you write	Describe a chart, table, map, process or life cycle	An essay giving your view on an issue
Minimum words	150	250
Weight	1/3 of the Writing score	2/3 of the Writing score
Suggested time	**20 minutes**	**35 minutes**

Recommended order: attempt Task 2 first. Spend 35 minutes on the essay, then 20 minutes on Task 1, and keep the last 5 minutes to check spelling, grammar and word count. Doing Task 2 first protects the task that carries more marks; if time runs short, a slightly rushed Task 1 costs far less than an unfinished essay.

Time	What to do
0–5 min	Task 2: read the question, identify the essay type, plan 3 main points
5–35 min	Task 2: write the essay (aim for 260–290 words)
35–55 min	Task 1: find the main trends, then write the report (aim for 160–190 words)
55–60 min	Check both answers

Marking criteria. Each task is marked on 4 criteria, equally weighted:

1. **Task Achievement** (Task 1) / **Task Response** (Task 2): answering every part of the question, with relevant ideas.
2. **Coherence and Cohesion**: clear paragraphs and good use of linking words (cohesive devices).
3. **Lexical Resource**: a wide, accurate range of vocabulary.
4. **Grammatical Range and Accuracy**: a mix of simple, compound and complex sentences with few errors.

Task 1: report types and structure

Task 1 asks for a factual report of at least 150 words in about 20 minutes. Never give your opinion here; only describe what the visual shows.

The 8 report types

Group	Type	Example question	What to focus on
Chart	Bar chart	Percentage of UK adults in five age groups using the Internet daily, 2003–2006	Highest and lowest bars, and how each group changed over time

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Group	Type	Example question	What to focus on
Chart	Pie chart	Coffee production, consumption and where the profit goes (three pies)	Biggest and smallest shares; use fractions (a quarter, half)
Chart	Line graph	Sales of children's books, adult fiction and educational books, 2002–2006	Overall trend of each line, peaks, lows and where lines cross
Chart	Table	Average retirement age of men and women in six countries	Group similar rows; pick out the highest and lowest values
Chart	Mixed chart	A bar chart of life expectancy in 2008 plus a table of the increase since 1953	Describe each chart, then link them
Diagram	Life cycle	The life cycle of the salmon	Each stage in order, size and time at each stage
Diagram	Process	How a simple water filter produces clean drinking water	Each step in order, using the passive voice
Diagram	Map	Changes to a coastal town between 1950 and 2007	What was removed, added or replaced, and where

Structure for bar chart, pie chart, line graph and table

1. **Para 1 – Introduction:** rephrase the question in your own words.
2. **Para 2 – Main trends:** describe the highest and lowest points and the biggest changes.
3. **Para 3 – Other details:** cover the remaining important figures and comparisons.
4. **Para 4 – Overall:** summarise the main impact or change (start with "Overall,…").

Structure for mixed chart

1. **Para 1 – Introduction:** rephrase the question.
2. **Para 2 – First chart:** explain the first chart.
3. **Para 3 – Second chart:** explain the second chart (if there are three charts, give each its own paragraph).
4. **Para 4 – Overall:** summarise the overall picture and link the charts.

Structure for life cycle and process

1. **Para 1 – Introduction:** rephrase the question and say how many stages there are.
2. **Para 2 – Stages:** describe the stages in order. If there are 4 stages, put 2 stages in Para 2 and 2 stages in Para 3.
3. **Para 3 – Overall:** summarise the whole cycle or process.

If a question combines a life cycle **and** a process, describe the life cycle in Para 2 and the process in Para 3.

Structure for map

1. **Para 1 – Introduction:** rephrase the question.
2. **Para 2 – First map:** describe the area as it was in the first map.
3. **Para 3 – Differences:** describe the second map and what changed (added, removed, replaced, extended).
4. **Para 4 – Overall:** summarise how the area developed.

For maps, reuse the location words from the Listening guide (to the north of, next to, opposite, in the south-east corner) and add change words: **was replaced by, was demolished, was converted into, was extended, was built, was relocated**.

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Task 1 language

Introduction phrases

- The bar / pie / line chart **illustrates** that...
- The chart / diagram **compares** the number of...
- The table **provides information about**...
- Data **is presented** regarding...
- The data **shows trends in**... over a period of...
- The graph / chart / table / map / diagram **shows / gives information about**...

What the data presents, and a synonym to avoid repetition:

Instead of	Use
the percentage of	the proportion of
the number of	the amount of (uncountable) / the quantity of
the change	the variation / the fluctuation
the increase	the growth
the decrease	the decline
people	citizens, residents, individuals
people who visited	tourists, visitors, guests
market	sales, revenue
brand	manufacturers, companies
share of	proportion of (for percentages)

Trend verbs

Movement	Verbs
Up	increase, rise, grow, climb, surge, soar, escalate
Down	decrease, fall, decline, drop, dip, plummet, shrink
No change	remain stable, remain steady, stay the same, stabilise, level off
Up and down	fluctuate, vary, change, be erratic, go up and down

Adverbs

Type	Adverb	Meaning
Large change	significantly	a big and important change
Large change	considerably	to a large degree
Large change	dramatically / sharply	a very big and sudden change
Large change	substantially	to a great extent
Medium change	moderately	noticeable but not large
Medium change	modestly	not very large
Small change	slightly	a very small change

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Type	Adverb	Meaning
Small change	marginally	almost no change
Small change	minimally	the least possible degree
Speed: fast	rapidly / swiftly	very fast
Speed: fast	quickly	fast, but less formal
Speed: slow	slowly	the opposite of rapidly
Speed: slow	gradually / steadily	slow and steady, regular
Frequency	frequently	repeatedly, often
Frequency	occasionally	irregularly, not all the time
Frequency	regularly	in a constant manner
Stability	consistently	following the same pattern
Stability	constantly	with no change
Stability	largely unchanged	almost the same, but not exactly
Comparison	similarly	the same trend
Comparison	comparatively / relatively	in comparison; fairly
Comparison	respectively	matches two or more items in order
Comparison	by contrast	the opposite trend
Comparison	meanwhile	a parallel trend at the same time
Approximation	approximately	about
Approximation	roughly	about (less formal, but acceptable)
Approximation	nearly / almost	close to a number

Comparing and contrasting

- compared to / as compared to / in comparison with / than
- as opposed to / as against
- in contrast to / whereas / while / on the other hand
- similarly / likewise
- the highest / the lowest / overtook / remained lower than
- **accounted for** / **represented**: “Cars accounted for 40% of journeys.”

Sentence starters

First body paragraph: At the beginning of the period,… / From 2000 onwards,… / Initially, the data reveals that… / During the first half of the period,… / A noticeable trend can be seen in… / There was a significant rise in…

Second body paragraph: In contrast,… / Meanwhile,… / On the other hand,… / By comparison,… / Comparatively,…

Conclusion: Overall, it is clear from the graph that… / In general,… / It can be seen that… / It can be observed that…

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Time phrases

Preposition	Examples
in	in 2000, in the 20th century, in the first ten years
for	for six months, for twenty years
during	during the first six months, during the first half of this century, during the remainder of the year
from … to	from September to November, from 2000 to 2005
between … and	between 2000 and 2020
other	over the period, in the final stage, in the later years

Numbers and percentages

Write small numbers (1–9) in words and larger numbers in figures: “Three countries experienced growth.” / “Sales increased to 25 million units.”

Percentage	Fraction	Phrase
10%	1/10	one in ten
20%	1/5	one-fifth / roughly one in five
25%	1/4	a quarter
33%	1/3	one-third
40%	2/5	two-fifths
50%	1/2	half
60%	3/5	three-fifths
67%	2/3	two-thirds
75%	3/4	three-quarters
80%	4/5	four-fifths
120%	1 1/5	one and one-fifth
133%	1 1/3	one and one-third
150%	1 1/2	one and a half
175%	1 3/4	one and three-quarters

Near values:

Value	Phrase
24.4%	just under a quarter
32%	almost a third
46.7% / 49%	almost half / nearly half / just under half
50.1%	just over half
77%	just over three-quarters / approximately three-quarters

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Value	Phrase
very small	a minority / a marginal percentage / a small proportion
very large	a majority / a substantial share / a significant proportion

Describing change in numbers: “increased **by** 10%” is the size of the change (40% to 50%); “rose **to** 50%” is the final value. “There was a drop of 10 percentage points between 2010 and 2015.” / “In 2015, the proportion of urban dwellers **stood at** 45%.” / “The figure rose by 15%, reaching 60% in 2020.”

Process and life cycle language

Use sequence words: **begin with, first, followed by, then, next, subsequently, after that, thereafter, finally, eventually**.

Use the **passive voice**, because the focus is on what happens, not who does it: “Impure water **is poured** into the container.” / “The mixture **is heated**, then **filtered** and **transported**.”

Task 2: essay types and structure

Task 2 is a formal essay of at least 250 words. The first step is always to identify the essay type from the question wording, because each type has its own structure.

The 5 essay types

Essay type	How the question is worded
Opinion (agree / disagree)	Do you agree? / Do you agree or disagree? / To what extent do you agree or disagree? / What is your opinion? / Is it a positive or negative development?
Discussion	Discuss both views and give your opinion.
Advantages / disadvantages	What are the advantages and disadvantages? / Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?
Problem & solution or cause & effect	What are the problems and solutions? / What are the causes and effects?
Two-part question	Two direct questions, e.g. What…? How…?

The 5-paragraph plan

Every essay type uses the same 5 paragraphs: **Introduction → Body 1 → Body 2 → Body 3 → Conclusion**. What changes is what goes into each paragraph.

Essay type	Introduction	Body 1	Body 2	Body 3	Conclusion
Opinion	Rephrase the question, state agree or disagree, list 3 reasons	Reason 1	Reason 2	Reason 3	Summary + opinion
Discussion	Rephrase the question, name both views and your opinion	First view	Second view	Your opinion	Summary + opinion
Advantages / disadvantages	Rephrase, give opinion if asked, list 2 advantages + 1 disadvantage (or the reverse)	Advantage 1	Advantage 2	Disadvantage 1	Summary + opinion

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Essay type	Introduction	Body 1	Body 2	Body 3	Conclusion
Problem & solution	Rephrase, list 2 problems + 1 solution (or 1 problem + 2 solutions)	Problem 1	Solution 1	Solution 2	Summary + opinion
Two-part question	Rephrase, answer both questions with 3 points in total (2 from one question, 1 from the other)	Answer 1	Answer 2	Answer 3	Summary + opinion

Start the conclusion with **In conclusion,** or **To sum up,**.

The 4-sentence body paragraph

Each body paragraph follows the same pattern, and each sentence starts with a cohesive device.

Sentence	Purpose	Body 1 starter	Body 2 starter	Body 3 starter
1	State the point (rephrased from the question)	Firstly,...	Additionally,...	Finally,...
2	Explain the point	Moreover,...	Meanwhile,...	Subsequently,...
3	Give an example	For example,...	For instance,...	Such as... / To illustrate,...
4	Result or impact	Hence,...	Thus,...	As a result,...

Compound and complex sentences

A good essay mixes simple, compound and complex sentences.

Compound sentence: two independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (**for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so** – remember FANBOYS) with a comma, or by a semicolon.

- The cinema was sold out, **so** we watched a movie on TV.
- Our car broke down, **so** we took a taxi.
- The pain was really bad, **yet** he refused to see a doctor.
- I have never visited Moscow, **nor** have I been to St Petersburg.

Complex sentence: one independent clause plus one or more dependent clauses, joined by a **subordinating conjunction** (after, although, as, because, before, if, once, since, though, until, when, whenever, where, whether, while) or a **relative pronoun** (that, which, who, whom, whose).

- **Because** my coffee was too cold, I heated it in the microwave.
- **Although** he was wealthy, he was still unhappy.
- **If** you work hard, you will succeed.
- She is the woman **who** works at the hospital.

Cohesive devices

Purpose	Linking words
Adding	and, also, as well as, moreover, furthermore, in addition, additionally, along with
Sequencing	first / firstly, second / secondly, third / thirdly, next, before, after, then, subsequently, finally

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Purpose	Linking words
Emphasising	above all, in particular, especially, significantly, indeed, notably, chiefly, mainly, clearly
Contrasting	however, whereas, instead of, nevertheless, alternatively, otherwise, unlike, on the other hand, conversely, yet
Comparing	similarly, likewise, as with, just as, like, equally, not only… but also, in the same way
Cause and effect	because, so, therefore, thus, consequently, hence, as a result, due to this
Exceptions	but, although, unless, if not, except, apart from, aside from, as long as
Illustrating	for example, such as, for instance, in the case of, as revealed by, as illustrated by

Task 2 phrases by section

Introduction

- In today's society, it is widely acknowledged that…
- It is commonly believed that…
- It is often said that… / Many people claim that…
- With the advancement of technology,…
- The issue of [topic] has gained prominence in recent years.
- [Topic] is a hotly debated topic that often divides opinion.
- [Topic] is often discussed yet rarely understood.
- It is essential to address the issue of [topic] due to its significant implications.
- It is imperative to examine the impact of [topic] on…
- This essay will discuss… / The purpose of this essay is to analyse…

Introducing a point (body paragraphs)

- To begin with,… / To start with,… / Firstly, it is important to consider…
- One key aspect to consider is…
- Another important factor to consider is… / Another point worth noting is…
- Another compelling argument is…
- Moreover,… / Furthermore,… / Additionally,… / In addition,… / On top of that,…
- It should also be noted that…
- Firstly… / Secondly… / Thirdly… / Lastly… / Finally… / Last but not least…

Expressing results and presenting ideas (body paragraphs)

- As a result,… / …has led to… / …has resulted in…
- Consequently,… / Therefore,… / Thus,… / Hence,…
- On account of… / Due to…
- This indicates that… / This suggests that… / It can be inferred that…
- This leads to the conclusion that…
- When it comes to… / In terms of… / With respect to…
- Not only… but also…
- According to experts,… / There are those who argue that… / Research has found that…

Concluding paragraph

- In conclusion,… / To conclude,… / To sum up,… / In summary,…
- Overall,… / In essence,… / Ultimately,… / In a nutshell,…

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- Taking all factors into account,...
- It is evident that...

Topic vocabulary

Task 2 topics usually come from a small set of themes. Learn the words for each theme and use them in your own sentences.

Education

Word	Meaning
pedagogy / pedagogical	the method and practice of teaching
curriculum	the subjects in a course of study
syllabus	an outline of the topics in a course
scholarly / academic	relating to study and learning
proficient	skilled or competent in a subject
literacy	the ability to read and write
discourse	formal discussion or debate
intellectual	relating to thinking and understanding ideas
didactic	intended to teach, often a moral lesson
cognition	the mental process of gaining knowledge and understanding
enrichment	improving the quality or value of something
e-learning / distance learning	studying online or remotely
aptitude	natural ability, especially in learning
assessment	evaluating someone’s ability or work
instruction / tutoring	teaching, often one-on-one for tutoring
accreditation	official recognition that standards are met
classroom management	keeping lessons running smoothly
extracurricular	activities outside the normal curriculum
specialisation	becoming an expert in one subject

Weather

Word	Meaning
meteorology	the scientific study of weather
precipitation	rain, snow, sleet or hail
barometer	an instrument that measures air pressure
climate	the long-term weather pattern of an area
forecast	a prediction of future weather
monsoon	a seasonal wind bringing heavy rain

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Word	Meaning
hailstorm / thunderstorm	storms with hail / with thunder and lightning
cyclone / tornado	rotating storm systems / a violent rotating column of air
drought	a long period of very low rainfall
blizzard	a severe snowstorm with strong winds
fog	a thick cloud of water droplets near the ground
windward	the side facing the wind

Politics

Word	Meaning
democracy	government by the people through elected representatives
legislature	the elected body that makes laws
diplomacy	negotiation between nations
ideology	a system of political or economic beliefs
governance	the process of governing and managing public policy
constituency	voters in an area who elect a representative
partisanship	strong bias towards one party
sovereignty	supreme power or authority of a state
autocracy	rule by one person or a small group
bureaucracy	government where officials make most decisions
coalition	an alliance of parties forming a government
secularism	separating religion from government
nationalism	strong patriotic feeling for one’s nation
anarchy	the absence of government

Relationships

Word	Meaning
companionship	having a close relationship with someone
intimacy	close familiarity or friendship
affection	a gentle feeling of fondness
commitment	being dedicated to a person or cause
trust	firm belief in someone’s reliability
loyalty	being faithful to someone
empathy	understanding and sharing another’s feelings
respect	admiration for someone’s qualities
partnership	a relationship of mutual cooperation

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Word	Meaning
support	giving help or encouragement
conflict	a serious disagreement
compatibility	being able to exist together without conflict
compromise	an agreement where both sides give something up

Health

Word	Meaning
well-being / wellness	being healthy, comfortable and happy
fitness	being physically fit and healthy
nutrition	getting the food needed for health and growth
hygiene	cleanliness that prevents disease
immunity	the body’s ability to resist infection
prevention	stopping something before it happens
mental health	psychological and emotional well-being
rehabilitation	restoring someone to normal life after illness or addiction
therapy	treatment to relieve or heal a disorder
holistic	treating the whole person, not just symptoms
resilience	the ability to recover quickly from difficulties
diagnosis	identifying an illness from its symptoms

Science and technology

Word	Meaning
innovation	a new idea, method or device
advancement	progress or development
research	systematic study to establish facts
breakthrough	a sudden, important discovery
experimentation	trying out new ideas or methods
evolution	gradual development from simple to complex
automation	using machines to do work automatically
digitalisation	converting information into digital form
sustainability	being able to continue long term
biotechnology	using biological processes for industry and medicine
nanotechnology	technology at the scale of atoms and molecules
cybersecurity	protecting electronic data from criminal use
genetic engineering	changing an organism’s genes

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Word	Meaning
renewable energy	energy from sources that do not run out, like wind and solar
artificial intelligence	computer systems that do tasks needing human intelligence

Arts

Word	Meaning
aesthetics	the appreciation of beauty in art
creativity	using imagination to create something
expression	making thoughts or feelings known through art
artistry	creative skill
masterpiece	a work of outstanding skill
muse	a source of inspiration for an artist
genre	a category of art with a shared style
sculpture	art made by carving or casting
performance art	visual art combined with live performance
composition	the arrangement of elements in a work
critique	a detailed analysis of a work
exhibition	a public display of art
abstract	art using shapes and colours rather than real objects

Employment

Word	Meaning
employment rate	the percentage of the workforce in work
job market	the jobs available and the people seeking them
labour force	everyone employed or seeking work
unemployment benefits	money paid to people out of work
workforce diversity	variety of people in a workplace
job security	confidence that your job will last
career advancement	progress in your profession
freelancing	working on short contracts for several clients
gig economy	a job market of short-term and freelance work
work-life balance	balance between job and personal life
remote work	working outside the office, often from home
occupational health and safety	protecting workers' well-being
retrenchment	cutting jobs for economic reasons
human resources	the department that manages staff

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Word	Meaning
skill acquisition	learning new skills to improve employability

Tourism

Word	Meaning
destination	a place people travel to
tourist attraction	a place that draws visitors
hospitality	the friendly reception of guests
cultural heritage	traditions and objects passed down from the past
heritage site	a protected place of cultural or natural importance
ecotourism / sustainable tourism	travel that protects nature and helps local people
adventure tourism	travel for challenging outdoor activities
travel agency	a business that books trips
tourist visa	a document allowing a visitor to enter a country
tour guide	a person who leads tourists
souvenir	a keepsake bought to remember a trip
travel insurance	cover against problems while travelling
backpacking	travelling cheaply with a backpack

Environmental issues

Word	Meaning
climate change	long-term shifts in temperature and weather, mainly caused by human activity
pollution	harmful substances in air, water or soil
conservation	protecting natural resources and ecosystems
biodiversity	the variety of living things in a habitat
deforestation	clearing forests for farming or building
environmental sustainability	meeting today’s needs without harming future generations
carbon footprint	the greenhouse gases produced by a person or activity
ecological footprint	the land needed to support a population’s consumption
ecosystem restoration	repairing damaged ecosystems
wildlife conservation	protecting endangered species and habitats
green technology	technology that reduces environmental harm
ocean acidification	seawater becoming more acidic from absorbed CO_2
environmental policy	laws and rules to protect the environment
sustainable agriculture	farming that protects soil and water long term

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Globalisation

Word	Meaning
international trade	exchange of goods and services across borders
free trade	trade without tariffs or quotas
economic interdependence	countries relying on each other economically
transnational corporations / multinationalism	companies operating in many countries
outsourcing	contracting work to outside or overseas suppliers
global supply chain	the worldwide network that produces and delivers goods
cultural homogenisation	local cultures becoming more alike
cultural hybridisation	mixing cultures to create new forms
cultural imperialism	one culture dominating others
digital divide	the gap between those with and without internet access
migration	people moving from one place to another
global governance	international institutions that coordinate nations
interconnectedness	being linked through global networks
global citizenship	feeling part of a world community

Alternatives for common words

Repeating simple words lowers your vocabulary score. Swap them for these, but only use a word if you are sure of its meaning.

Instead of	Use
make up	constitute, comprise, form, compose, represent
get rid of	eradicate, eliminate, remove, abolish, dispose of
big / huge	large, substantial, immense, considerable, significant, vast, colossal, massive
good	excellent, outstanding, exceptional, superior, beneficial, advantageous, positive, valuable, constructive
good (moral)	virtuous, righteous, ethical, honourable, commendable
bad	poor, inadequate, inferior, substandard, unacceptable, detrimental, harmful, adverse, deleterious
bad (moral)	wicked, malevolent, corrupt, immoral, malicious, sinister
very bad	horrendous, appalling, dreadful, atrocious
happy	content, joyful, delighted, cheerful, satisfied, pleased, elated, jubilant
very happy	ecstatic, exuberant, euphoric, blissful, radiant
sad	melancholy, sorrowful, gloomy, despondent, dejected, disheartened, crestfallen, downcast, forlorn

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Instead of	Use
nice	pleasant, agreeable, charming, delightful, enjoyable, genial
angry	furious, enraged, irate, incensed, livid, indignant
beautiful	gorgeous, stunning, exquisite, lovely, elegant, breathtaking
ugly	unattractive, unsightly, hideous, repulsive, revolting
fast	rapid, swift, quick, speedy, expeditious
slow	sluggish, gradual, leisurely, lethargic
smart	intelligent, clever, astute, brilliant, sharp
stupid	foolish, unintelligent, ignorant, senseless, idiotic
cunning	devious, sly, crafty, wily
interesting	fascinating, intriguing, captivating, engrossing, riveting
boring	tedious, monotonous, dull, repetitive, tiresome
difficult	challenging, demanding, arduous, formidable, daunting, strenuous
easy	simple, effortless, uncomplicated, straightforward
well spoken	eloquent, articulate, fluent
rumour	hearsay, gossip, speculation

Do’s and don’ts

Do	Don’t
Attempt Task 2 first (35 min), then Task 1 (20 min), and keep 5 minutes to check	Don’t spend more than 20 minutes on Task 1; it is worth half as much as Task 2
Spend 3–5 minutes planning before you write	Don’t start writing before you know the essay type and your 3 main points
Write at least 150 words (Task 1) and 250 words (Task 2); aim a little above	Don’t write far too much; more words means more chances for mistakes and less checking time
Rephrase the question in your own words	Don’t copy sentences from the question; copied words are not counted
Answer every part of the question	Don’t write about unrelated ideas, however good they are
Use synonyms to avoid repeating the same word	Don’t use a “big” word if you are not sure of its meaning
Mix simple, compound and complex sentences	Don’t write only very short or only very long sentences
Start new paragraphs and sentences with suitable cohesive devices	Don’t overuse linking words in every sentence; it sounds mechanical
Give an overview (“Overall,…”) in every Task 1 report	Don’t give your opinion in Task 1
State your opinion clearly in Task 2 when the question asks for it	Don’t change your opinion halfway through the essay

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Do	Don’t
Use the passive voice for process diagrams	Don’t describe every single number in a chart; select the main features
Write in a formal style	Don’t use contractions (don’t, can’t), slang, or bullet points
Check spelling and punctuation at the end	Don’t leave either task unfinished; an incomplete answer loses heavily

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